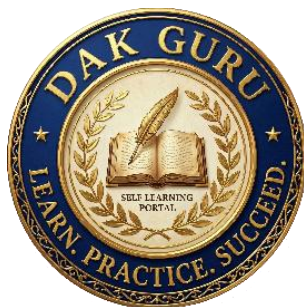




DAK GURU

A Self-Learning Portal

www.dakguru.com

DEPARTMENTAL EXAMINATION · STUDY MATERIAL

Instructions on the Maintenance of the Annual Performance Assessment Report (APAR)

*Comprehensive notes for the LDCE — Inspector Posts (IP)
and PS Group 'B' departmental examinations*

Updated to reflect the orders, amendments and instructions
in force as on June 2026

DISCLAIMER

This booklet has been prepared by Dak Guru solely as a study aid for departmental examination aspirants. It has been compiled from primary sources — the Office Memoranda, rules and instructions of the Department of Personnel & Training (DoPT) and the Department of Posts — and states the position believed to be in force as on June 2026. While every care has been taken to ensure accuracy and to incorporate the latest amendments, statutory rules and departmental instructions are revised from time to time. Readers must therefore verify the current position from the original Office Memoranda, Gazette notifications and official Government sources before relying on any provision for service or official purposes. Dak Guru accepts no liability for any error, omission or consequence arising from the use of this material.

1. Meaning, Purpose and Legal Framework

The **Annual Performance Assessment Report (APAR)** is the principal document through which the performance of a Government servant is recorded every year. It was earlier known as the **Annual Confidential Report (ACR)**; the name was changed to “APAR” to emphasise that it is an instrument of objective *assessment* rather than a secret, confidential record. The report is written by the immediate superior officer (the **Reporting Officer**) in an **objective and impartial** manner.

The performance of every Government servant is assessed for the period **1 April to 31 March** (the reporting year = financial year). The APAR provides the basic and vital inputs for deciding **confirmation, promotion, deputation, foreign assignment and empanelment**.

Twin objectives of the APAR system

- To **improve the performance** of the Government servant in his/her present job; and
- To **assess the potential** of the Government servant and prepare him/her for higher responsibilities in future.

The ultimate aim is the optimal achievement of Government policies and programmes. Accordingly, the focus of the Reporting Officer must be **developmental rather than judgmental** — the APAR should be a true indicator of the officer’s achievement, not merely a tool of control or discipline.

Governing instructions (key sources)

APAR of Central Civil Services is governed by executive instructions of the DoPT (consolidated in the DoPT Brochure on Preparation and Maintenance of APARs), while the All India Services are governed by the statutory **AIS (Performance Appraisal Report) Rules, 2007**. The principal instructions relevant for examination purposes are:

- **DoPT O.M. No. 21011/1/2005-Estt.(A)(Pt-II) dated 23.07.2009** — numerical grading, pen-picture, weightages and the time schedule (Annexure-III).
- **DoPT O.M. No. 21011/1/2005-Estt.(A)(Pt-II) dated 14.05.2009** — communication of all entries to the officer for transparency (from the reporting year 2008-09).
- **DoPT O.M. No. 21011/10/2025-PP(A-II) dated 09.04.2025** — *revised* time schedule for preparation/completion of APAR (see Section 14 and the Annexure).

2. Structure of the APAR — the Four Sections

The APAR form is divided into **four sections**. Each section is filled by a different authority:

Section	Contents and who fills it
Section-I	Basic Information — service particulars of the officer reported upon; filled by the Administration / Personnel (Custodian) and verified by the officer.
Section-II	Self-Appraisal — filled by the Appraisee (officer reported upon).
Section-III	Appraisal — filled by the Reporting Officer (numerical grades + pen-picture).
Section-IV	Review — filled by the Reviewing Officer . Where an Accepting Authority is prescribed in a cadre, it records its remarks/overall grade thereafter.

3. Initiation and Self-Appraisal

The APAR is **initiated by the Government servant reported upon** (the appraisee), who completes the self-appraisal in Section-II.

- **Description of duties:** a **brief** description of the duties performed, **not exceeding 100 words**. (Swamy's Handbook indicates up to about 300 words; the DoPT proforma prescribes 100 words.)
- **Performance details:** the targets set, achievements against each target, shortfalls (if any), constraints faced, and areas of **greater achievement** / significant contribution during the year.
- **Certificates:** the date of submission of the Annual **Immovable Property Return (IPR)** is to be furnished (the IPR is due by 31 January each year).

If the self-appraisal is not received within the first week of the schedule, the Reporting Officer reminds the officer in writing; if it is still not submitted by the due date, the Reporting Officer may proceed to write the report on the basis of his/her own knowledge of the officer's work and conduct.

4. Eligibility and Time-Limits for Reporting / Reviewing Officers

Minimum experience — three months (90 days)

Officers at both the Reporting and Reviewing levels must have supervised the work and conduct of the Government servant for at least **three months (90 days)** during the reporting period before they can record their assessment.

Counting the 3-month period — leave is excluded

When computing the qualifying period, any **Earned Leave, Maternity Leave, Child Care Leave or Study Leave exceeding 15 days** is deducted from the total period spent on the post. Leave of short duration (15 days or less) is ignored. This is also a ground for a **No Report Certificate** where the requisite supervision is not available (*per DoP SPARROW guidelines, F.No. 25-4/2013-SPG*).

Special situations

- **Two or more reports in a year:** where the officer worked under different Reporting Officers, each Reporting Officer having at least 3 months' experience may write a separate (part-period) report.
- **No eligible Reporting Officer:** if no Reporting Officer has the requisite 3 months' experience, the **Reviewing Officer** himself initiates the report as the Reporting Officer, and it is then reviewed by the next higher authority.
- **Retirement / demission of office:** a Reporting or Reviewing Officer may write/review the report of subordinates **within one month** of his/her retirement or demission of office.
- **Suspension:** an officer placed under suspension may write/review the report **within two months** from the date of suspension **or within one month** from the date the report was due (whichever gives more time). If he/she was under suspension for the **major part** of the period of report, he/she should not write/review it.
- **Transfer:** where the report has to be written by a Reporting Officer who is being transferred, it should be written **at the time of transfer or immediately thereafter** — and not deferred to the end of the year.

- **Near relative:** as far as possible, a near relative should not be posted under a Reporting Authority for a long period. If unavoidable, the APAR is written by the Reviewing Officer.

5. Numerical Grading and Weightage

Numerical grades are awarded by the Reporting and Reviewing authorities for the **quality of work output, personal attributes and functional competence**, on a scale of **1 to 10** (1 = lowest, 10 = highest).

The **overall grade** (on a 1–10 scale) is computed on the following weightage (*DoPT O.M. dated 23.07.2009, Annexure-II*):

- **Assessment of Work Output — 40%**
- **Assessment of Personal Attributes — 30%**
- **Assessment of Functional Competency — 30%**

The overall grading is obtained by adding the mean value of each group of indicators in proportion to the weightage assigned, and is recorded up to **two decimal places** (e.g., 6.57 is recorded as 6.57; there is no rounding off).

Grades of **1 or 2** (low) and **9 or 10** (high) are expected to be rare and must be specifically justified in the pen-picture — by stated failures for low grades and stated accomplishments for high grades. The officer should be rated against a larger population of his/her peers.

6. Overall Grade and Verbal Grading Bands

The overall numerical grade is translated into a verbal grade, and an average score is used for empanelment/promotion calculations (*DoPT O.M. dated 23.07.2009, Annexure-I*):

Overall numerical grade	Score for averaging	Verbal grade
8 to 10	9	Outstanding
6 and below 8	7	Very Good
4 and below 6	5	Good
Below 4	0 (zero)	<i>Below the 'Good' band</i>

Note: “Very Good” covers any overall score from **6.0 up to (but not including) 8.0**; a score of exactly 6.0 is the floor of “Very Good”, while 5.9 falls in the “Good” band.

7. Integrity, Pen-Picture and Filling Guidelines

Integrity column

The Reporting Officer must record one of the following on integrity (*DoPT O.M. dated 11.02.2016, reiterating para 5.2 of O.M. dated 20.05.1972*):

- **“Beyond doubt.”**
- **“Since the integrity of the officer is doubtful, a secret note is attached.”**
- **“The officer’s work has not been watched for sufficient time to form a definite judgment, but nothing adverse has been reported about him/her.”**

Pen-picture

In place of the old separate “overall assessment” column, the Reporting Officer records a **pen-picture** (overall qualities, strengths, lesser strengths and attitude towards weaker sections) in **not more than 100 words**. The Reviewing Officer adds remarks on this pen-picture and must specifically indicate any difference of opinion with the Reporting Officer, with reasons.

Other guidelines

- **Absence and training:** the period of absence (leave, training, etc.) and details of training attended during the year must be recorded.
- **Penalty entry:** an entry regarding a penalty is recorded in the APAR of the year in which the **punishment order is issued** (not the year of the offence), noting the period when the offence was committed.
- **Pasting strips:** affixing typed paper strips/slips into the APAR is restricted; entries are to be made directly.

8. Performance Benchmarks — Promotion (DPC) vs MACP

A common point of confusion is that the benchmark for **promotion** and for **MACP** are not identical. They must be distinguished.

(a) Promotion through the DPC

The Departmental Promotion Committee (DPC) assesses suitability with reference to the APARs of the **five preceding years** (*DoPT O.M. No. 22011/7/98-Estt.(D) dated 06.10.2000*). The **benchmark depends on the level of the promotion post**:

- **“Good”** for promotion from Group ‘B’ to the lowest rung of Group ‘A’; and
- **“Very Good”** for the higher Group ‘A’ posts (*DoPT O.M. dated 10.03.1989 read with O.M. dated 06.10.2000*).

Where the mode of promotion is “selection”, the DPC grades each officer **“Fit”** or **“Unfit”** against the prescribed benchmark. Those graded **Fit** are placed in the select panel in order of their inter-se seniority; there is no supersession among officers graded Fit.

(b) MACP (financial upgradation)

For financial upgradation under the **Modified Assured Career Progression Scheme (MACPS)** — granted on completion of 10, 20 and 30 years — the benchmark was enhanced from “Good” to **“Very Good”** for **all posts**, on the recommendation of the 7th CPC (Para 5.1.45).

- **Effective date:** the “Very Good” benchmark applies to MACP falling due **on or after 25.07.2016** (*DoPT O.M. No. 35034/3/2015-Estt.(D) dated 28.09.2016; consolidated MACP guidelines dated 22.10.2019*).
- **Score required:** the overall grading of the reckonable APARs must be at least **“Very Good” (i.e., an overall score of 6.0 or more)**; there is no averaging across years.
- **Pre-2016 APARs:** for years prior to 25.07.2016 the earlier “Good” benchmark continues, and a “Good” grading of that period may be treated as “Very Good” while considering such cases.

In all cases the **Reviewing Officer’s grading is treated as final** and is the grade taken into account for DPC and MACP purposes.

9. Gaps in Reporting — No Report Certificate (NRC)

Wherever there is a gap in the APAR for any part of the reporting period, the Custodian responsible for maintaining the APAR must place a **“No Report Certificate (NRC)”** in the dossier, stating the specific reason. Valid reasons include:

- the officer did not work for at least 3 months under any Reporting Officer;

- the officer was on leave / training (EL, Maternity, CCL or Study Leave exceeding 15 days);
- the officer was on unauthorised absence (where factually established); or
- the report could not be completed because the time-limit lapsed and the (retired) Reporting/Reviewing Officer forfeited the right to record remarks.

Where a Reporting/Reviewing Officer does not initiate/complete the report within the stipulated time, he/she **forfeits the right** to enter any remarks, and a certificate to that effect is added to the APAR.

10. Special Categories

- **Honorary / purely part-time officials:** no APAR need be written for them.
- **Deputation / Foreign Service:** for a Central Government servant on deputation to another Department, a State Government or on Foreign Service, the APAR is maintained by the **parent Department**. The periodicity is generally the same as in the parent Department, and it is the parent Department's responsibility to obtain and maintain such reports.

11. Custody and Preservation of APARs

Custody

- **Group 'A' and Group 'B':** kept by the **Head of the Department** or any authority specified by him.
- **Group 'C':** kept by the authority specified by the Head of the Department.
- **Limit:** in no case may the APAR be kept by an authority **higher than the appointing authority**.

When a dossier must be sent to an outside authority (for selection, promotion or appointment), the **original is retained** with the cadre authority and only a **photocopy** is sent; the photocopy must be **destroyed immediately** after the purpose is served.

Preservation period

Event	APAR retained for
Death of the Government servant	2 years from the date of death

Event	APAR retained for
Retirement / dismissal / removal / resignation	5 years from the date of the event

12. Transparency — Disclosure, Representation and Communication

From the reporting year **2008-09** onwards, the **full APAR** — including the overall grade and the assessment of integrity — is communicated to the officer reported upon (*DoPT O.M. dated 14.05.2009; following Dev Dutt v. Union of India*).

- **Representation:** the officer may make a representation against any entry within **15 days** from the date of disclosure of the APAR.
- **Disposal:** the Competent Authority decides the representation objectively, on the material before it, **within one month (30 days)** of receipt, and may reject, accept or modify the APAR. Its decision is final.

13. SPARROW — the Online APAR System

SPARROW (Smart Performance Appraisal Report Recording Online Window) is the online system, developed by the **National Informatics Centre (NIC)**, for recording APARs electronically. Online recording was introduced for the All India Services and Central Group 'A' services from the **reporting year 2014-15** and has since been progressively extended to Group 'B' cadres.

In the Department of Posts, APARs of **Group 'A' officers** (IPoS and MMS, Group 'A') are recorded through SPARROW, with the roll-out being extended to other cadres. The four sections of the form are completed online by the officer reported upon, the Reporting Officer and the Reviewing Officer in sequence, with an in-built workflow and Custodian role.

14. Recent Developments (2024–2026)

(a) Revised time schedule — from reporting year 2024-25

By **DoPT O.M. No. 21011/10/2025-PP(A-II) dated 09.04.2025**, Annexure-III of the 23.07.2009 O.M. was revised. Key changes: distribution of blank forms is now **1 April**

(earlier 31 March); submission of self-appraisal is now **15 May** (earlier 15 April); and an **auto-forward mechanism** has been introduced so that the file moves to the next stage automatically if action is not taken. The revised schedule is at the **Annexure** to this booklet.

(b) Mandatory iGOT-Karmayogi courses to be reflected in the APAR

By DoPT O.M. dated 04.07.2025 (corrigendum dated 19.08.2025), under Mission Karmayogi, all Central Government employees and AIS officers must complete prescribed courses on the **iGOT-Karmayogi** platform every year — illustratively a **minimum of 6 courses** per level. Completion status is fetched from iGOT into a new sub-table under “Training Programmes Attended” in **Part-I of the APAR**, from the reporting period **2025-26**. A Comprehensive Assessment (Level-2 assessment for 3 of the 6 courses, minimum 50% pass) is also to be reflected via SPARROW.

(c) One-time extension for reporting year 2025-26

By DoPT O.M. dated 13.05.2026, as a one-time measure (owing to officers’ engagement in recent State Legislature elections), the APAR timelines for the reporting year 2025-26 were relaxed/extended. This is a one-time relaxation; the standard schedule remains that of the 09.04.2025 O.M.

15. Department of Posts — Reporting / Reviewing Channels

The following are the general (illustrative) reporting and reviewing channels for the main cadres in the Department of Posts. The **exact authorities are governed by the relevant Recruitment Rules and Circle-specific orders** and may vary; aspirants should confirm the position applicable in their Circle.

Cadre	Reporting Officer	Reviewing Officer
IP / ASP	SSP / SP of the Division	Director of Postal Services (DPS)
PS Group ‘B’	DPS	PMG / CPMG
PA / LSG / HSG	SSP / SP of the Division	As per Circle norms
MTS / Postman / MG	Inspector Posts / Postmaster / HRO	As per Circle norms

- **Self-appraisal:** in the Department of Posts, submission of self-appraisal is generally required for officials of the **LSG cadre and above**.
- **Custody (illustrative):** the DPS (HQ) is the custodian of IP/ASP APARs, and the Sr. Private Secretary to the CPMG is the custodian of PS Group 'B' APARs of the Circle.



Annexure Revised Time Schedule for Preparation / Completion of APAR

Effective from the reporting year **2024-25** (reporting year = financial year) — DoPT O.M. No. 21011/10/2025-PP(A-II) dated 09.04.2025.

S.No.	Activity	Due date	Auto-forward
1	Distribution of blank APAR forms to all concerned	1 April	—
2	Submission of self-appraisal by the officer reported upon	15 May	16 May
3	Report by Reporting Officer to Reviewing Officer	30 June	1 July
4	Report completed by Reviewing Officer / sent to Admn. or Accepting Authority	31 July	1 August
5	Appraisal by Accepting Authority (wherever provided)	31 August	1 September
6	Disclosure to the officer — (a) no Accepting Authority / (b) with Accepting Authority	(a) 1 Sept (b) 15 Sept	—
7	Representation, if any, by the officer reported upon	15 days from disclosure	—
8	Forwarding of representation — (a) no Accepting Authority / (b) with Accepting Authority	(a) 21 Sept (b) 6 Oct	—
9	Disposal of representation by the Competent Authority	Within 1 month of receipt	—
10	Communication of the decision by the APAR Cell	15 November	—
11	End of the entire APAR process — finally taken on record	30 November	—

Quick Revision Key Numbers at a Glance

Reporting year	1 April – 31 March (= financial year)
Minimum supervision experience	3 months (90 days)
Leave excluded from that period	EL / Maternity / CCL / Study Leave exceeding 15 days
Duty description & pen-picture	Each not exceeding 100 words
Numerical grading scale	1 to 10 (1 lowest, 10 highest)
Weightage	Work output 40% : Personal attributes 30% : Functional competency 30%
Grading bands	8–10 Outstanding (9) · 6–<8 Very Good (7) · 4–<6 Good (5) · <4 → 0
MACP benchmark	“Very Good” (overall score ≥ 6.0) for MACP due on/after 25.07.2016
DPC — years assessed	APARs of the 5 preceding years
Write report after retirement	Within 1 month of retirement / demission
Write report when suspended	Within 2 months of suspension OR 1 month from due date
Representation against APAR	Within 15 days of disclosure; disposal within 1 month
Preservation — death	2 years from date of death
Preservation — retirement, etc.	5 years from the event
Key dates (RY 2024-25 onwards)	Blank forms 1 Apr · Self-appraisal 15 May · RO→30 Jun · ReO→31 Jul · Process ends 30 Nov

Prepared by Dak Guru — *Learn. Practice. Succeed.* Always confirm the current position from the original Office Memoranda before relying on any provision.